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Doctrinal Basis of the British Reformed Fellowship

“The basis of the BRF shall be the inspired, infallible, inerrant Scriptures of the Old and New Testaments as summarized and systematized in the Reformed confessions, specifically the *Three Forms of Unity* and the *Westminster Standards*.”

British Reformed Fellowship

Founded in 1990 by a group of Reformed Christians concerned for the defence of the Historic Reformed Faith in the British Isles.

Aims and Objectives

1. To promote knowledge of the Reformed Faith as is defined in the Doctrinal Basis through the publication of a quarterly journal (*British Reformed Journal*) and by organizing a biennial national family conference and other conferences and lectures as opportunities arise, through media, internet and any lawful means.
2. To facilitate the networking of Reformed Christians scattered throughout the British Isles, and to enable opportunities for supporting and communicating with one another.
3. To promote Reformed causes such as Christian education, Christian benevolence, biblical ecumenism and fellowship throughout the British Isles.
4. To provide a source of advice, information and support to Reformed Christians who are living and working in isolation. To provide practical answers to difficult questions arising among Reformed Christians isolated from fellowship.

Editorial: More Loving Than God? (2)

Samuel Watterson

Limits of Christian Love and Cautions

In the last editorial, we examined the blasphemous argument made by both Arminians and hypo-Calvinists that they are more loving than the God who wills and desires to save some but not others. Besides noting that a broader, narrower or different scope is not a valid measure of love, we concluded that man's moral obligation to love is, in fact, necessarily and properly restricted in various ways. Now I intend to demonstrate this with various examples and later I will explain Scripture's own criteria for measuring love. Considering the limited scope of man's love, we turn the argument on its head by asking why the Arminian or hypo-Calvinist should demand that God loves every single person who ever lived, when He demands that men must not have such a universal and promiscuous love.

In taking this approach, we are acknowledging the important relation between ethics and theology, especially the relation between Reformed ethics and Reformed theology. Reformed doctrine is not merely distinctive on account of its theology (such as God's eternal election and reprobation or His everlasting covenant). In fact, if it has a distinctive theology, then it must necessarily also have distinctive ethics because right ethics flow from right theology. Many of the objections against Reformed theology are built upon this implication. Arminians argue that Reformed theology must be wrong because it will lead to bad ethics (or what they presume are bad ethics). For example, they claim that teaching that God will preserve His elect from falling will make people careless. Some draw this conclusion because they do not understand (or ignore) what Reformed theology teaches about God's use of necessary means in causing His saints to persevere. In this case, Reformed theology gives us the right reasons for good ethics, for it teaches the power and goal of God in sanctification, along with all manner of good and high motivations which He employs as means. These are much better ethics than those implied by Arminianism. Arminianism denies the power of God in sanctification, and lacks many of the strong motivations and encouragements provided by Reformed theology.

In this case, I am making the argument that Arminian ethics (which their argument simply assumes without any proof or explanation) are not the ethics of Scripture at all and not the ethics which consistent Reformed theology would require. There is a warning here for ourselves and an admonition for the hypo-Calvinists who have already uncritically swallowed the ethics of the Arminian. If good ethics must be derived from good theology, bad ethics can and do corrupt good theology. Universalism in ethics, over time and quite naturally, will produce universalist theology. The invention and use of Jesse Morell's argument illustrates this. Churches which are hypo-Calvinist today did not become hypo-Calvinist overnight or for no reason. There may be many reasons, but I expect that a significant reason for many is that they allowed the ethics of the Arminians, universalists and the whole wicked world to infect their own ethics and, therefore, also their theology. Losing one's orthodox theology because of bad practices is a judgment of God which has been repeated often in church history (Rev. 2:5; 3:3). We must be on guard against this danger in our own lives, in our families and in our churches.

My method is to show examples of thoughts, words or deeds from God's people which were approved by God in both the Old and the New Testaments, and which demonstrate hatred rather than love towards other humans. First of all, despite differences in the external administration of the covenant, such that there was an earthly temple and an earthly nation with civil laws and physical wars, the moral law remains the same because God does not change. Furthermore, the Old Testament was given specifically to provide examples for our learning and admonition (Rom. 15:4; I Cor. 10:11). We will see fewer examples in the New Testament since it is geared more towards didactic teaching, even in the Gospels (which we will review further). The sparsity of New Testament examples generally makes these examples especially significant and even more so because the Lord Jesus Christ gave us His paramount example to follow in all things (John 13:15). We also see fewer examples in the New Testament because this period is characterized by the gospel being preached to the nations, and Christ's gathering and saving a catholic church, so that this period is an especially rich time of God's grace and mercy before the final judgment (Luke 4:19; 9:54-56; 19:10; John 3:17; Acts 17:30; II Cor. 6:2).

Because of our natural inclination to hate God and our neighbour, a word of caution is appropriate before we begin. None of these examples ought to be

misinterpreted as an excuse to entertain or even consider personal vendettas or vindictiveness, to harbour or nurture personal grudges, or to seek personal revenge by violent or any other means (Matt. 5:44). That error belonged to the leaven of the Pharisees. In every one of these cases, this sanctified hatred is necessary for the sake of the Lord. From the beginning, God put enmity between the devil and the woman, Eve, and between the children of the devil and her spiritual children (Gen. 3:15). Any enmity which does not fall into that category is evil from the outset, as evil in principle as Cain murdering his righteous brother Abel (I John 3:10-15). Furthermore, though the children of the devil may be numerous and deceitful, insofar as is reasonably possible, our interactions are to be marked first of all by seeking peace, forbearing and applying the judgment of charity (Ps. 120:6-7; Rom. 12:18; I Cor. 13:7).

Finally, even in extreme cases, we must still restrain ourselves, refusing to take vengeance for ourselves but crying out to God to bring judgment quickly against His adversaries who are our oppressors for His sake (Luke 18:1-8). In such cases, we choose rather to flee persecution and heap coals on their heads by our goodness, not rendering evil for evil, and so overcome evil with good (Rom. 12:17-21; I Pet. 3:8-17). In suffering evil unjustly (while choosing, as Jesus did, first to flee or avoid evil when we can; cf. Matt. 10:23; John 7:1), we follow the example of Christ and glorify Him by our witness. Having this foundation, we can proceed with care, considering that Cain's murderous wickedness was far worse in the sight of God than Jehoshaphat's sin in helping Ahab (II Chron. 19:2). In so doing, we may hope with God's blessing to avoid the errors of turning to the left or to the right (Deut. 5:32).

Holy War, Judicial Hatred and Imprecations

In reviewing the Old Testament, we need to anticipate some objections coming from the universalist viewpoint. The first is crude Marcionism, which we immediately reject as a denial of the doctrine of Scripture, and of the immutability and righteousness of God. Second, no one denies that the death penalty was required (even from Noah's day in cases of murder, unlike in the days of Cain when the earth became filled with violence; Gen. 9:5-6) and that Israel was commanded to kill her enemies in various wars. Some will argue that there should be no death penalty today and that there are no justifiable

wars, claiming that these things belonged exclusively to the time of types and shadows. Indeed, many universalists are also strict pacifists.

Certainly, the death penalty for particular crimes belonged to the Mosaic civil law, and many of the Old Testament wars were intended in part to illustrate types and shadows for our learning. However, that the death penalty was already given in Noah's time with the reasons for it and the commendation of it also in the New Testament indicates that it should still be part of the criminal justice system today (Rom. 13:4). The civil power is described as a minister of God bearing the sword to avenge by executing wrath on evil-doers. The sword was a Roman instrument of capital punishment.

Similarly, the Roman soldiers asking how to show the fruit of repentance were not told by John the Baptist that they had to become strict pacifists. Rather they were told not to threaten or to accuse anyone falsely and to be content with their wages (Luke 3:14). Indeed, a centurion during Christ's ministry was commended as having greater faith than any in Israel (Matt. 8:10), and another devout centurion was first among the Gentiles to be brought the gospel by Peter (Acts 10:1-6). These godly men were soldiers who were expected to go to war for the Roman Empire.

However, even if this were not the case, it would still remain that, at least in the Old Testament, to execute the death penalty upon a criminal was not an act of love towards him, as the universalists would understand love. By executing the criminal, he no longer has any space to repent but goes to the judgment in the hands of the righteous God (Heb. 9:27; Rev. 2:21). For the same reason, to kill a heathen in an Old Testament war was not an act of love for the enemy combatant. Having that clear at the outset, we will understand the significance of so many examples. We do not dispute, of course, that the executioner or the soldier in such cases may be performing an act of love towards God and his neighbour, who is delivered from the danger of the murderer or heathen enemy soldier. This does not at all detract from the fact that the act shows no love for the murderer or enemy soldier, but rather hatred, just as if one had said, "May you now die in your impenitence and blood-guiltiness, and fall into the hands of the just God who executes His wrath upon the wicked."

There is one other frivolous objection which may be brought. One might claim many of these examples, such as the conquest of Canaan, should be

disqualified because God in these instances specifically told them to do these deeds and the particular case cannot prove the general. But this admission actually proves our claim that God does not command a universal unqualified unlimited love. If He had, then these particular cases would put God at odds with Himself and deny the immutable universal applicability of His moral standard. Just one example is enough to prove our contention that the assumed premise of the “more loving than God” argument is false but these examples will prove much more.

One of the clearest early examples is the call of Moses and his subsequent obedience. Moses is told explicitly that, by confronting Pharaoh and through God’s hardening of Pharaoh’s heart, He will smite Egypt with wonders (Ex. 3:19-20; 4:21-23). Though Moses knows it will lead to the devastation of Egypt and the destruction of Pharaoh, he does not object to the Lord that his words and actions as a prophet would not be loving to Pharaoh and the Egyptians. It is not only God that destroys the Egyptians. In obedience to God, Moses stretches out his hand so that the waters of the Red Sea return (Ex. 14:26-28). It is further remarkable that Israel with Moses then sings a godly song of triumph, rejoicing and dancing at the destruction of the Egyptians by God (Ex. 15:1-21). Where is any love or even sorrow for Pharaoh and the Egyptians here? There was no place for it in the face of the revelation of God’s judgment on them.

There are many examples in the wilderness wanderings. Joshua’s battle against Amalek is striking. While Joshua led the Israelites in battle, Moses had to keep his arms raised until the Amalekites were defeated (Ex. 17:8-16). There was no room to love those whom God had determined to destroy utterly. This was not only true of some outside the nation of Israel. When Moses returned from Mount Sinai to destroy the golden calf, he called those who were on the Lord’s side to slay even brother, companion or neighbour of the idolaters (Ex. 32:26-29). The sons of Levi were called not to love the three thousand whom they slew.

The congregation was told to separate themselves from the tents of Korah, Dathan and Abiram in their rebellion, so that God could destroy them all (Num. 16:24-34). They were not to have mercy or compassion on them by clinging to them. When Balaam’s counsel led the people into whoredom and

idolatry with the daughters of Moab and Midian, Phinehas turned away God's wrath by running Zimri and Cozbi through with a javelin (Num. 25:1-15). His swift and decisive action was not with any love for Zimri or Cozbi, but with the intent to destroy them and purge the evil out of Israel, and so deliver the people from the plague. Phinehas's zeal in this execution of judgment was highly commended as righteousness unto all generations (Ps. 106:28-31). He would not have been commended for suggesting that they all simply ought to love Zimri and Cozbi, and spare them. Later Moses was instructed by God to take vengeance on the Midianites and destroy them (Num. 31:1-2). Rather than commend their mercy and love in taking all the women and children as captives, Moses was righteously angry with them (Num. 31:9-17).

We move on to examples in the law in which the Israelites were told specifically to show no pity or mercy or compassion to certain people. Regarding the Canaanites, false prophets, murderers and false witnesses, the refrain is repeated: "thine eye shall not pity" (Deut. 7:16; 13:8-9; 19:13, 21). Christ's commentary on the last verse cited above is not to overthrow it, but rather that the Christian should patiently and humbly bear his punishment (Matt. 5:38-40). Such civil punishments are still far less than what our sins deserve. In any case, these judicial punishments explicitly forbid the kind of unlimited pity and love that is assumed by universalists to be fundamental morality.

Deuteronomy provides us with at least two other notable examples. First, the tribes on Mount Ebal were expected to pronounce curses upon all those who violated the law of God and all the people were to concur (Deut. 27:13-26). Many today reckon that pronouncing a curse upon anyone in any circumstance is sinful (e.g., by wrongly presuming that all men are in the image of God, cf. James 3:9). Certainly a curse is not love but the opposite. But God required His people to pronounce these curses (and we will later see more examples of godly curses). Second, God's people are called to rejoice in His vengeance, even in the avenging of their own blood (Deut. 32:35-43). They are not called here to love God's adversaries, those who are rewarded with vengeance for their hatred of Him.

Time and space would fail us to go through every example of holy hatred in the conquest of Canaan, but we would be remiss not to note especially the execution of the kings. Many of these thirty-one kings, if not all, were first

saved alive and then executed in captivity. Having been killed, their bodies were hung on a tree until evening, as Joshua did to the king of Jericho (Josh. 8:29; 10:26-27). Moses explains for us that this signified that these kings (as representatives of their nations or cities) were accursed of God (Deut. 21:23). This hanging was not love or mercy but the proclamation of a curse.

We move on to the time of the Judges and another example of godly cursing. Deborah and Barak sang of the command from the angel of the Lord that the people of God must curse vehemently the inhabitants of Meroz, because they refused to fight for God's cause against Sisera (Judg. 5:23). This is not an instance of God cursing but not His people. This passage is notable because of the specific command to curse from Jesus Christ (the angel of the Lord and captain of the host of Jehovah, cf. Josh. 5:14). In fact, it is a direct and emphatic imperative, repeated in a double-barrelled form for a total of three times. There is no suggestion in the text that this was merely some kind of warning or rebuke with a desire for repentance. A curse is not a rebuke or admonition but a pronouncement of (or request for) God's retributive, not corrective, punishment and wrath. It is contrasted with the pronouncement of God's blessing upon Jael. Jael must be blessed and, therefore, the inhabitants of Meroz must be cursed, and in such a way that the people of God participate in this cursing. The logic here is simple: God's people must agree with God.

We will mention just a few more examples that happen to occur to me as particularly poignant and memorable. When Samson (praised as a hero of faith in Hebrews 11) is given renewed strength, it is so that he may destroy the Philistines, not in love for them, but in love for God and His people, and in judgment against the Philistines for being idolaters, oppressors and enemies of God (Judg. 16:28). When children of Belial in Benjamin commit atrocities, the Israelites rightly demand for them to be delivered up to be put to death (Judg. 20:13). The Israelites did not love these vile men but, out of love for God and His people, their calling was to hate them, to destroy them and put the evil away from Israel. In the pursuit of this righteous cause, almost an entire tribe was wiped out because, in misguided loyalty and stubbornness, the Benjamites refused to hate the wicked enemies of God.

Another example of great grief and failure caused by the refusal to exercise holy hatred was King Saul who brought trouble on Israel, David's house and

his own progeny, from whom the kingship was taken. He was told in no uncertain terms to destroy the Amalekites utterly, again because they were avowed and bitter enemies of God's people, and God had sworn to destroy them (Ex. 17:14-16). People in our day have forgotten that our God's name and revelation is *Jehovah-nissi*, the sovereign, faithful, unchanging, covenant-keeping God, whose war banner is raised perpetually against His enemies from generation to generation until their remembrance is utterly wiped out. Jehovah does not tire or grow weary of waging His war, as if His holy hatred could mellow and soften into mercy and forgiveness. If His anger is but for a moment, it is because the object of His anger is not His hated enemy but His beloved children (Ps. 30:5; 103:8-18; Isa. 54:7-10). How different was Saul! He saw an opportunity for gain and despised the love, service and devotion he owed to his Creator, whom King Agag hated. King Agag, in his turn, made an appeal to Samuel's natural compassion for his common humanity, as if the prophet would ignore the command of God for the sake of such an hypocritical appeal. Many today would prefer to listen to Agag and judge Samuel as unloving, harsh and cruel, but Samuel understood the place of holy hatred for God's enemies, though he sorrowed for Saul (I Sam. 15:32-16:1).

We know that ordinarily prophets in Scripture were especially holy men, as was the case with Samuel and Elijah. Yet both of these did not refrain from executing God's judgments according to their callings, putting God's enemies to the sword (either by their own hands or by direct orders). It was not because Elijah loved the prophets of Baal that, after mocking them, he slew them in hundreds by the brook Kishon (I Kings 18:40). Similarly, it was only when the angel of the Lord instructed him otherwise (after the captain begged mercy rather than to order the prophet) that Elijah ceased to call down fire from heaven to destroy king Ahaziah's captains with their fifties (II Kings 1:9-16). He understood that these messengers of Baal-worshipping Ahaziah were enemies of God. Unlike Samuel and Elijah, Jehoshaphat forgot his allegiance to the Lord and had to be rebuked by Hanani, as we noted previously (II Chron. 19:2-3).

Nehemiah shines very brightly in Scripture as a holy man dedicated to God and the welfare of His people in a dark time of weakness, oppression and small things. Yet Nehemiah repeatedly pronounces unambiguous imprecations against Sanballat and his cohorts, even praying that their sins should never

be blotted out. That is, his godly and specific prayer, not even informed by any specific prophecy or instruction of God, is that He should not forgive or justify these men, but that they should stand exposed to His eternal wrath and indignation for their sin of angering Him by opposing the builders (Neh. 4:4-5). There are such apostate men still today who set themselves up against those who labour in building the walls of the city of God, against whom such prayers are appropriate (I John 2:18-19; cf. Gal. 1:8-9; 5:12).

Such imprecations, utterly contrary to the misguided ideas of unlimited universal love, are not rare in Scripture and even our beloved book of Psalms is full of them. A simple internet search listed 14 “major” imprecatory psalms (Ps. 5; 10; 17; 35; 58; 59; 69; 70; 79; 83; 109; 129; 137; 140), which is almost 10%! This means that on any given Lord’s day, in a psalm-singing church with two services and four psalms in each service, all else being equal, the probability of singing at least one imprecatory psalm is at least 75%! This is why churches without a theology in harmony with the imprecatory psalms are typically not psalm-singing churches! Many psalms with imprecations also refer to Christ in His earthly ministry or are otherwise alluded to in the New Testament (Ps. 31; 35; 40; 41; 55; 68; 69; 109). Even more psalms express sanctified hatred in some form or another (we noted Psalm 139:21-22 previously).

I will highlight just two further striking examples of a holy attitude at odds with universal love put into mouths of all who obey the enduring and apostolic commandment to sing psalms (Ps. 95:2; 105:2; Eph. 5:19; Col. 3:16; James 5:13). In one instance, the righteous see the destruction of the wicked (who oppressed them, as Doeg the Edomite did), and “fear” and “laugh” at him, even mocking as in agreement with the Lord’s laughing and mocking recorded elsewhere (Ps. 52:6-7; cf. Ps. 2:4). Though done out of a reverent God-fearing heart, the psalmist (with the psalm-singing congregation of God) is so devoid of love for this wicked enemy of God that he mocks and laughs at the absurdity of the wicked’s boastful arrogance against God in face of His destruction of the wicked. Besides glorifying God in the righteousness of His judgments, such mocking edifies us also in this respect, namely, that in the fear of God we might better avoid falling into the same foolish pride and wickedness.

The other attitude regarding the destruction of the wicked exemplified for us in the psalms is rejoicing in the God who executes judgment which is glori-

ously righteous and which also delivers us from the oppression of the wicked (Ps. 58:10-11). Though we may and ought to sorrow (in measure), especially for those closest to us, even family, familiar friends and acquaintances with others who share our common humanity, flesh and blood from Adam (as all together the offspring of God in this sense), we may not allow our earthly ties to interfere with our allegiance to God and even our rejoicing in His just judgments (II Sam. 1:17-27; 18:33-19:7; Acts 17:26-28; Rom. 9:1-3; II Cor. 6:10).

Vengeance on Enemies of the Gospel

Unavoidably, in our review of Old Testament illustrations, we have touched upon the New Testament but it is astonishing how hastily with regards to this subject some appeal to Marcion or at least some form of dispensationalism. In the interests of closing the door on this particular line of objection, we will continue. When Christ sent out the disciples to preach throughout Judea and Galilee, He taught them to carry out a very specific practice which is contrary to the modern doctrine of unlimited universal love. Whenever they were rejected in a certain place and the people showed themselves impenitent, the disciples were to shake off the dust from their feet as a testimony against them (Matt. 10:14; Mark 6:11; Luke 9:5).

This was not an act of love, but essentially a promise that they would receive greater judgment than Sodom and Gomorrah (Matt. 10:15). For the recipients of this sign, it would have been better for them never to have heard the gospel at all. This imprecatory practice was followed also by the missionaries in the book of Acts and it always, in some sense, attends the preaching of the gospel (Acts 13:51; 18:6; II Cor. 2:16). In case we should think that Christ suffered from this universal unlimited love delusion, He Himself reiterated these curses (Matt. 11:20-24; Luke 10:10-15). Christ's practice of cursing (which some today imagine to be unfitting for His followers) includes His curses against the hypocritical and impenitent Pharisees, even to their faces for their oppression of God's people (Matt. 11:21; 23:13-35).

I find it striking that Paul's first recorded miracle as an apostle (who was himself blinded on the Damascus road until Ananias restored his sight) was to strike Elymas the sorcerer with blindness (Acts 13:8-11). Paul denounces him

as a “child of the devil” (ordinarily a term reserved for the reprobate wicked) and an enemy of all righteousness. The miracle was performed not out of love for Elymas or to bring Elymas to repentance, but to rebuke and expose him while confirming Paul’s ministry. Paul’s ministry included many such words and deeds against the enemies of the gospel, not in love for them, but in love for God and His people (e.g., Gal. 1:8-9; 5:12; II Tim. 4:14). Following the example and precedent of the Old Testament, the people of God in the New Testament are also expected to pronounce curses upon God’s enemies (I Cor. 16:22; Jude 11).

Although the primary purpose of church discipline is to gain the repentance of the subject, similar to the preaching, it is carried out with the understanding that in many cases this will not be achieved. In such cases, it is a manifestation of the church’s hatred for God’s enemies in removing the wicked from their company and having no fellowship with them so that, when carried out properly and faithfully, the church’s rejection of them is a testimony of God’s rejection of them (I Cor. 5:11; Eph. 5:11; Titus 3:10; II John 10-11; cf. John 20:23).

The clear New Testament teaching concerning apostasy and the unforgivable sin also has implications for not practicing an indiscriminate love that knows no bounds (Mark 3:28-29; Heb. 6:4-9; 10:28-31). John, the “apostle of love,” makes it explicit that we are not to pray for the repentance of those who have committed the sin “unto death” (I John 5:16). Certainly we may not be too quick to judge who has apostatized in committing such a sin, but John nevertheless mentions this a real and practical concern in the context of having called his readers’ attention to the evident “antichrists” who had departed from among them by denying that Jesus is the Christ, either by their grossly heretical doctrines or scandalous lives of blatant hypocrisy. It would surely be an error in the other extreme to conclude that we may never judge a person to have committed this sin, considering our calling to judge (I Cor. 6:2-3). After describing the reprobate at length concerning their sins, hypocrisy and predestination, Jude presents what I understand to be a sharp contrast. Unlike those who have gone the way of Cain, Balaam and Korah, there are others for whom we must have compassion or who must be saved “with fear” (Jude 22-23). The implication is that we do not have the calling to be compassionate or to try to save those regarding whom Jude has given such strong warning.

In fact, there are examples in the New Testament which in their context at least strongly suggest that this judgment has been made, even by name (I Tim. 1:20; II Tim. 2:17). That the Thessalonians are specifically told not to count one who disobeys Paul's epistle as an enemy (but to admonish them as a brother) implies that there are other cases in which such an attitude would be appropriate or even the norm for such rejection of clear apostolic instruction (II Thess. 3:15). To treat in love as brothers or friends those who have so highly offended God that there is no possibility of their repentance and forgiveness is certainly at odds with a profession of love for God.

Some quote Ephesians 6:12 as if this suggests that the devil does not also have flesh-and-blood servants and children (like Judas Iscariot or Elymas), but that the enemies of the church are only unclean spirits. Since this conclusion would be an absurd contradiction, the text speaks of the ultimate spiritual roots of our enemies. We do not strive against flesh and blood with carnal weapons (as in the pictures and shadows of the Old Testament times), but we look beyond the flesh and blood of our adversaries to the demonic origin of their wickedness, and ultimately take up the battle with spiritual weapons and spiritual armour, by the Word of God, by faith and by prayer (cf. Isa. 54:16-17; Matt. 10:28; II Cor. 10:3-5; Eph. 6:13-18).

Finally, the book of Revelation presents the church suffering under persecution with an attitude contrary to the one being promoted as Christian love today. The church, even the souls of perfected saints in heaven, longs for the day of Christ's vengeance (Rev. 6:10). Specifically, although there is no personal vindictiveness implied, they long for their own blood to be avenged. The prayers of God's suffering and oppressed people ascend with incense, and fire from God's altar is cast upon the earth in a manifestation of God's judgment and wrath (Rev. 8:3-5). These prayers are the spiritual weapons of God's elect who cry to him night and day for His justice to be executed in the earth (Luke 18:1-8). When this judgment finally comes in all its fullness and terrible glory to destroy the ungodly world system and whore of Babylon, the antichristian kingdom of the beast, along with his unholy prophet and the dragon behind it all (Satan), the church overflows in triumphant rejoicing and worship (Rev. 18:20; 19:1-6). This promise of God avenging His people upon the wicked is the comfort of His suffering people who mourn and pray in this present evil age (Isa. 61:2).

Consequences of Universalism

God's people are deprived of that comfort when the sickly sweet doctrine of an unlimited universal love is taught as if it were a divine commandment. When this false doctrine works itself out in a church, there are both harmful theological and practical consequences. Once it is claimed that we must love every single person who ever lived without exception and without limit, naturally it is claimed that God's love is also so promiscuous. Then either God's love fails or it is not eternal or it is not holy and righteous. Clear biblical doctrines concerning God's sovereignty, election and reprobation, apostasy and the unforgivable sin are carefully swept under the carpet. God's judgments, both temporal and eternal, are ignored. The devil and man's free will are raised up as having some kind of power beyond God's control to try to excuse Him (essentially, this is dualism or polytheism), despite the clear teaching of Scripture (Mark 1:27; Prov. 21:1). Hell is rarely spoken about and often denied completely. Because Scripture cannot be understood in this system, Bible reading declines or is replaced by reading disconnected thoughts from carefully selected verses designed to soothe the emotions and conscience of the reader.

Repentance is no longer so important, since God's love and the Christian's love must be the same for the impenitent. Forgiveness is required without the necessity of repentance and fellowship is required without the necessity of holiness. The judgment of charity tempered with vigilant wisdom is replaced by wilfully blind naivety and folly (Matt. 10:16). Strict pacifism, denying even self-defence, is demanded. These practical errors expose people to all manner of dangers from predators of all sorts who thrive in such environments. Civilization itself sows the seeds of its own destruction, when such a philosophy works itself out in the culture and society. In the church, Christian discipline is jettisoned and excommunication is never to be spoken of again. The Lord's Supper and baptism must be open to all without asking too many questions. The preaching must not make anyone feel uncomfortable or under condemnation. The ultimate sin becomes judging another or excluding them in any way. This is the humanism of the godless world, not Christianity. Those who follow the trajectory of this false doctrine create for themselves an idol, just as much as if they had chopped down tree, carved a piece of wood and overlaid it with gold. Their idol is in their own image: the image of man, the way they want God to be. This is the very opposite to Scripture's presentation: God made

man in His image, not the other way around. First, we must know God and His love, then we will understand His calling for us with respect to our love.

Related to Jesse Morell's ridiculous argument that he is more loving than the sovereign God who loved Jacob and hated Esau (Rom. 9:13), is the superficially more persuasive claim that Christ is somehow more loving than the God who does not desire the salvation of the reprobate:

[S]ome have suggested that Christ here [in Matthew 23:37 and Luke 19:41-42] expresses human feelings and desires and as such we learn nothing of the nature of God. First we acknowledge that if it were any other human this argument might carry some weight. But we are talking about Humanity in its perfect state. Are we to believe that "holy humanity is more generous and tender than God"?¹

The proponents of the well-meant offer would have us believe that such arguments trump everything else we have considered in Scripture. While it is true that Christ's love is expressed also through His necessarily limited human nature and that He has a human will in distinction to the divine will (contrary to the monothelite heresy), it is not true that His love is ever at odds with the love of God. In the passages cited, Christ's love is expressed for His elect and beloved people only. In fact, in the context of Matthew 23, Christ is opposing the Pharisees with cursing. When He says, "how often would I have gathered thy children ... and ye would not," He is not expressing love for those who futilely and wickedly opposed His will to gather the church, but explaining why the people of Jerusalem will be cut off in their generations (Matt. 23:38). His attitude toward them is not one of love, but of righteous anger and condemnation, entirely in agreement with the judgments of God against them.

When, in Luke 19, Christ weeps over the city (not actually the same occasion as in Matthew 23), His grief is for the great wickedness of those who have brought this terrible ruin upon Jerusalem and for His elect sheep in the midst of Jerusalem (cf. Gen. 6:5-6). There is much more complexity here with regard

¹ K. W. Stebbins, *Christ Freely Offered* (Australia: Covenant Press, 1999), p. 46; citing R. L. Dabney, "God's Indiscriminate Proposals of Mercy, as Related to His Power, Wisdom and Sincerity," *Discussions: Evangelical and Theological*, vol. 1 (London: Banner, 1967), p. 308.

to the significance of Jerusalem as an Old Testament type and the organic nature of the church, but this answer will suffice. Even Judas Iscariot was not properly an object of Christ's love. He was certainly treated as a companion for a time, privileged with the other disciples, but from the beginning Christ knew who would betray Him (John 6:64-71). Christ knows His sheep with the knowledge of love (John 10:14). To the others, including Judas Iscariot, He will say on the last day, "I never knew you: depart from me, ye that work iniquity" (Matt. 7:23).

We have seen that God's love must have a different scope to ours but, to speak as a fool, does this different scope somehow make our love better or morally superior to God's? First of all, it is not really true that the scope of human love can ever be broader than God's. We do not even know every person who lives in the present, let alone every person who has ever lived or who will live. If we do not really know them, we cannot legitimately claim to love them. At most, we could only boast hypothetically that, if we knew them, we would endeavour to love them. Whether we actually would love them is another question considering our capacity to love is very small, even as regenerated Christians. But God has known and loved all His people, more than the stars in the sky for multitude, through all ages and in eternity with an everlasting love. Even in this measure, our love cannot compare to God's. But, if scope is not a legitimate measure of love, how does Scripture itself measure love and how should God's love be measured, considering that it is one of His attributes (I John 4:16)? We will have to consider the proper measure of God's love and a biblical definition of love with the command to love next time (DV).

Unbiblical Divorce and Adulterous Remarriage: A Scandal

Prof. David J. Engelsma

Introduction

With the subject of this final speech of the conference, we come to the topic and way of life that will prove that we are sincere in our confession of the importance of the Christian family.¹ Few professing Christians and few nominally Christian churches will deny the importance of the family outright. But most today show that their confession of the family's importance is mere empty religious talk by approving divorce for virtually any reason and by approving the subsequent remarriage. Those who keep track of such things inform us that the rate of divorce in the so-called evangelical churches is just as high as it is in the world of the ungodly. This rate is high—more than 50% of all marriages, that is, more than half of them.

Because divorce, with the remarriage that usually follows, is obviously the destruction of the family, those persons and those churches that approve divorce and permit it are not sincere in their profession of the importance of the Christian family. Whether the explanation is sheer falsehood or self-deceit, they lie when they claim to honour the family. In fact, they are part of the juggernaut of our day that is destroying the family.

The churches, the organization and the persons that promote and participate in this conference are sincere and serious in their conviction and confession concerning the fundamental importance of the family for the Christian church and the believing child of God. They are sincere and serious about the family as God the Creator and Jesus Christ the Saviour are sincere and serious about the family.

Therefore, we are appalled by the tolerance and even approval of divorce and remarriage, not only in the world but also in the churches. To us, it is a scandal, nothing less. By scandal, we mean not merely behaviour on the part

¹ This article is based upon the last speech at the 2018 BRF Conference.

of professing Christians that is outrageously wicked. But we have in mind behaviour over which people stumble spiritually, so that they are hardened in their unbelief and in their rejection of the church and its message. It is conduct that occasions people's damnation.

Therefore also, we condemn the scandal and, in the face of the scandalous behaviour, we confess boldly and clearly God's truth about divorce and remarriage. For this confession, we may be mocked and opposed. We will not, however, be the occasion of the damnation of any.

The Biblical Truth

Let it be clear at the outset that we determine the truth about divorce and remarriage from the Word of God, that is, Holy Scripture. All those who approve remarriage after divorce go wrong regarding the authoritative basis of their doctrine and practice. The basis of their position and practice is the thinking and practice of the ungodly world in which the church finds herself. Or the basis is what is easy and satisfying for themselves, for their children and for the members of the churches. They find themselves married to a difficult husband or wife. Or they find a woman or a man who is much more attractive to them than their original spouse. They "fall in love" with another. Or a child divorces and remarries. Or a mate forsakes them. The circumstances of life, admittedly often difficult, determine their doctrine and their practice. Suddenly, remarriage after divorce becomes appealing.

Inasmuch as it is not the Word of God that determines the church's marriage doctrine and practice, an even more basic truth of the Christian religion is at stake: the sole authority of Scripture for all doctrine and conduct. Our authority for the right doctrine of marriage is not worldly culture or what is pleasing to ourselves. But the authority is the Word of God: "To the law and to the testimony: if they speak not according to this word, it is because there is no light in them" (Isa. 8:20).

Appeal to Scripture as the authority in the matter of divorce and remarriage was Jesus' response to the question by the Pharisees about divorce in Matthew 19. Matthew 19 is one of the most important passages in the Bible on divorce and remarriage. It is not only Jesus' teaching about divorce that is important in the passage. What was for Him the authority on the matter is

also important. The question concerned divorce. “Is it lawful for a man to put away his wife for every cause?” (v. 3). Jesus’ response indicated what was for Him the authority on the matter: “Have ye not read?” (v. 4), that is, Scripture, particularly in this case Genesis 1 and 2.

When the Pharisees argued by appealing to Moses’ permission of divorce in Deuteronomy 24, Jesus did not simply dismiss that passage. Rather, He insisted on the authority of the Genesis passage. “from the beginning it [i.e., the toleration of divorce] was not so” (v. 8). He explained that Moses in Deuteronomy was not commanding divorce, as the Pharisees suggested, but was “suffering” or putting up with, divorce. Also Moses regarded divorce as an evil. The cause of the evil was the “hardness” of the “hearts” of the Israelites (v. 8). What is seldom noted by churches and individuals who appeal to Moses’ toleration of divorce in support of divorce today is that they thus identify themselves as having “hard,” that is, unbelieving, hearts.

Old Testament Scripture was the authority for Jesus in the matter of divorce and it must be for us now in the time of the New Testament as well.

The passage in the Old Testament that is our authority concerning divorce and remarriage is, first of all, the account of the will of God the Creator as made known in the institution of marriage in the beginning, on the sixth day of creation, in His creation of mankind. This was the authority for Jesus in Matthew 19. Jesus referred to, and quoted in part, Genesis 2:21-24. The passage concludes, “and they shall be one flesh.” On the basis of this Old Testament Scripture, Jesus answered the question about the lawfulness of “putting away:” “What therefore God hath joined together, let not man put asunder” (Matt. 19:6). Setting aside for the moment what the doctrine of Genesis and of Jesus is, note the authority for Jesus: the will of God as revealed in the Bible, the Bible *only*. The authority for the doctrine of marriage was not for Jesus the popular teaching of Israel’s leaders. It was not the circumstances of the people. It was not the hardships that the truth about divorce and remarriage would have for some.

It was, “Have ye not read?”

What they then and we today read in Genesis 1 and 2, according to the explanation of Jesus in Matthew 19, is that there may be no divorce, in the

sense of the separation of the married couple so that they once again become “twain” or two, which would allow for marrying another. “Wherefore they are no more twain, but one flesh. What therefore God hath joined together, let not man put asunder” (v. 6). God has joined the two in a marvellous, mysterious union. Two individuals have become “one flesh.” “Flesh” does not only signify body, as expressed especially in sexual intimacy, but also soul, that is, mind, will and feeling. They have become a single realization of humanity. Only God may, and only God can, separate them, which He does in the death of one of them. So close, so binding, is the bond of marriage that even for God the separation of the two takes some doing: death.

There is one exception to the prohibition against divorce: “except it be for fornication” (v. 9). The sexual infidelity of one allows for (but does not require) a full, legal, permanent separation of “bed and board,” as the legal expression puts it. Even then, there may be no remarriage.

The prohibition of remarriage (for the “innocent party”) in the case of divorce on the ground of fornication is controversial with regard to the understanding of Matthew 19:9. The first part of the text might be explained as permitting the remarriage of the “innocent party.” The question is, Does the exception clause allow only for divorce or also for a subsequent remarriage. Against the explanation that applies the exception not only to the prohibition of divorce but also to the prohibition of remarriage, so that one divorced, on the ground of the fornication of his wife, is permitted to remarry, stand the following compelling, indeed conclusive, grounds.

First, there is the position in the text of the exception clause. It immediately follows the phrase, “put away his wife,” indicating that the Lord gives an exception to the prohibition against divorce and not to the prohibition of the likely subsequent remarriage.

Second, there is the truth that Jesus has just stated concerning God’s binding the two in marriage (v. 6). Man may not, and man cannot, put the two asunder whom God has so bound or joined, so as to permit remarriage to a third party. Grievous and sinfully powerful as fornication is, it is not powerful enough to rend asunder what God has joined together. Sin cannot undo what God has done.

Third, there is the clear testimony regarding the matter of remarriage after divorce on the ground of fornication in other, indeed parallel, passages of the Bible. Mark 10:11-12 is the parallel passage. Here, Jesus clearly forbids remarriage after divorce absolutely. "Whosoever shall put away his wife, and marry another, committeth adultery against her. And if a woman shall put away her husband, and be married to another, she committeth adultery." Remarriage after divorce (for any reason whatever) is adultery. There is no exception to the forbidding of remarriage after divorce, regardless of the ground of the divorce.

Fourth, there is the conclusive evidence of Matthew 19:9 itself. The text does not consist only of its first half, which one might explain as allowing for the remarriage of the "innocent party" after the permitted divorce. But there is also a second half: "and whoso marrieth her which is put away doth commit adultery." The woman in view here is the innocent party of the first part of the text. Her husband has divorced her, even though she has not committed fornication. He has subsequently married another. Her husband, therefore, is guilty of fornication or adultery. She is the "innocent party." If the explanation of the first part of the text as allowing for the remarriage of the "innocent party" is correct, she has the right to remarry. But Jesus expressly forbids her to remarry: "whoso marrieth her which is put away doth commit adultery." Her remarriage would be an adulterous marriage.

Matthew 19:9, which is the one passage in the New Testament to which advocates of the right to remarry of the "innocent party" in a divorce appeal, itself forbids the remarriage of the "innocent party." In Matthew 19:9, Jesus upholds the teaching of Genesis 2 and applies it in His day: one flesh, as joined by God, and, therefore, "let no man put asunder."

Elsewhere in the New Testament where the topic is remarriage, again and again Scripture forbids remarriage while the original spouse is still alive. The teaching is perfectly clear, so clear that, if it were not that the eyes of churches and theologians were blinded by other authorities and considerations, all would agree that remarriage after divorce is adultery. I refer among other passages to Luke 16:18, Romans 7:2-3, I Corinthians 7:10-11 and 39.

This last chapter is especially clear and conclusive. Verses 10 and 11 allow for divorce: "if she depart." This is the exception to the prohibition against divorce that Jesus allows in Matthew 19:9. But even in this instance she must

remain “unmarried.” One reason is the possibility of reconciliation to her husband: “or be reconciled to her husband” (I Cor. 7:11). It is worthy of note that, even though her husband has committed fornication against her, which allows her to “depart from her husband” (v. 10), he remains “her husband” (v. 11). Not even fornication and the divorce that follows have annulled the bond of marriage.

Verse 39 of I Corinthians 7 is also clear: “The wife is bound by the law as long as her husband liveth.” Only “if her husband be dead” is she “at liberty to be married” to another.

In perfect keeping with the institution of marriage as recorded in Genesis 1 and 2, the New Testament doctrine of marriage is that marriage is a life-long bond. There may be no divorce, except for fornication. All remarriage after divorce, including that of the “innocent party,” is adultery. Death, and death only, severs the bond so that the surviving mate is at liberty to marry again.

This witness of the Bible may be controversial today, because of the practice of the churches, because of the adulterous lives of professing Christians and because of the compromising theology of marriage of prominent theologians, but it is not because of any lack of clarity in the Bible on this important aspect of the Christian life.

The witness becomes even more forceful when we examine the reasons for the Bible’s doctrine of marriage.

The Fundamental Reasons

First, with specific regard to the subject of our conference—the Reformed family—this doctrine of marriage undergirds, safeguards and promotes the Christian, Reformed family. Divorce and remarriage destroy the family. Nothing destroys the family like divorce and remarriage. Divorce and remarriage are the all-out, ruinous assault on the original marriage, which is the main element of the family. They tend very powerfully to destroy the children, who are always deeply affected by the divorce of their parents and the break-up of their home. There are certainly sometimes survivors. The “innocent party,” the Christian whose wife wickedly divorces him, can exert himself on behalf of the salvation of his children. I Corinthians 7:14 teaches that the children

of the marriage of a believer and an unbeliever (which the divorcing and remarrying mate shows himself or herself to be) are “holy.”

Nevertheless, the children in a divorce are deeply troubled by the divorce; their family-life, their precious family-life, is shattered. Likely, the divorce is ruinous of their spiritual and emotional welfare. Every pastor is well aware of this devastating effect of divorce upon the children. Some twenty years ago, a well-known and highly respected non-Christian sociologist and psychologist wrote a highly acclaimed book detailing the results of her study of the effects of divorce upon the children involved.² Her study showed that these children suffered seriously the detrimental effects upon themselves of the divorce of their parents long into their adulthood, some twenty or thirty or more years after the divorce occurred. The implication of the book, if it was not expressly stated, was that parents should stay together in marriage and the home for the sake of their children.

The analysis of this study by a Christian is that God instituted the human race in marriage and family. Disregard of this institution is met by divine judgment upon all involved. God wills faithfulness in marriage on behalf of family. God wills family. God is the God of family. Baal and Asherah are the gods of sexual promiscuity and, therefore, of divorce and remarriage. Molech is the god of the sacrifice of children on the altar of parents seeking their own satisfaction. But the God of the Christian faith is the God of the family. A Christian, especially a married Christian and a child in a Christian family, adores Him for this perfection.

We can penetrate still more deeply, as we discover the reasons for the biblical doctrine of the unbreakable bond of marriage. Marriage is the bright and beautiful symbol of the marriage of Christ and the church. This is the gospel in the second half of Ephesians 5. The real and ultimately important marriage is not ours, but the marriage of Jesus and His church. This marriage is the relation of love, first, of Jesus for us and, then, of us for Jesus, that is the bond of salvation that the Bible calls the “covenant.” In the Old Testament, the marriage which was the covenant took the typical form of the covenant of Jehovah with Israel (Eze. 16). In the New Testament, the reality of the

² Judith S. Wallerstein, Julia M. Lewis and Sandra Blakeslee, *The Unexpected Legacy of Divorce* (New York, NY: Hyperion, 2000).

marriage is the bond of love between Jesus and the elect, believing church (Eph. 5). God's covenant is salvation, and Ephesians 5:22-33 teaches that the symbol of this divine covenant is the marriage of the believing man and the believing woman. Marriage, the apostle proclaims, is a "great mystery: but I speak concerning Christ and the church" (v. 32).

Our highest calling with our marriage, therefore, is not to please ourselves or even to please our mate, but to show forth the truth of Christ and the church, in the presence of God and before the watching world. Divorce, and then taking another husband or wife, debases the symbolism of Christ and the church as faithful to each other. Divorce and remarriage in the church by professing Christians not only testifies to the world that Christians are as unfaithful to their vows and to marriage as is the world, but, in addition, that Christ and the church are unfaithful to each other. Because Christ is God's Christ, representing God's faithfulness to His church, divorce and remarriage in the church testifies to the unfaithfulness of God in His love for His church. Divorce and remarriage, particularly in the sphere of the church by professing Christians, is blasphemy.

The glorious message of Ezekiel 16—as grand a passage on marriage in the Old Testament as Ephesians 5 is in the New Testament—is that God is faithful even to His adulterous wife, Israel/church.

The fundamental reason for the biblical doctrine and practice of marriage, then, is the nature of God in Jesus Christ. God is the God of faithfulness to His people, even unto the cross of Himself in human flesh. The idols are fickle; God is faithful. This, we may, and must, display in our marriages. How do we do this, in the adulterous, unfaithful time in which we live?

The Practical Implications

Reformed husbands and wives are to live faithfully with their spouse. They are to regard each other as the one given by God for life. The wife regards her husband as the Christ and herself as the church, symbolically. The husband views his wife as the church and himself as the Christ, symbolically. They live together, day in and day out, in the consciousness of the symbolism of Ephesians 5. So far does this go, that the husband whose wife has committed

fornication, and repents, is moved to reconciliation by the gracious behaviour of Jehovah God towards His wife in Ezekiel 16.

Husbands and wives see and take up their calling as, above all, to be faithful, not only with regard to sexual fidelity but also with regard to all aspects of marital life, for the sake of their precious Saviour, Jesus Christ. Although their own happiness in marriage is at stake, they live together rightly, not only or even mainly, for the sake of their own happiness but for the sake of pleasing Jesus Christ. This motivates them to behaviour that even their own happiness could not accomplish.

Although the sexual is not all there is to marital faithfulness, it is an extremely important aspect of the faithfulness. To married Christians comes the divine admonition, “Flee fornication” (I Cor. 6:18). “Flee” indicates both the enticing power of fornication, and the importance to marriage of the sexual fidelity of husband and wife. Some sins Christians ought to battle courageously. Fornication is one sin from which every man and woman ought to flee, as it were, cowardly. Rather than to face it down at close quarters and contend with it, it is wisdom to run away from the temptation of it. David courageously took on the giant, Goliath, in direct, face-to-face combat; Joseph, on the other hand, wisely fled the seductive and seducing wife of Potiphar. In close and compromising quarters, the strength of the temptation of fornication is too strong for even the holiest of Christians to resist. The admonition to flee fornication is a warning that by itself alone makes many movies, television programmes and books off-limits to the Christian. Lust is strong already in fallen human nature (which the Christian retains), without the nurture of it by the devil’s cultural meat and drink.

Another implication of the biblical doctrine of marriage is that the unmarried Christian youth must marry wisely, keeping in mind that marriage is for life, that it must symbolize Christ and the church, and that the one they marry should show the spiritual qualities that will make the lifelong marriage peaceful. To those who are unmarried, the exhortation is: marry “in the Lord” (I Cor. 7:39). Even then, when one marries a fellow member of the church, a young man or a young woman must avoid one who, though a professing Christian, shows characteristics that will make marriage miserable: an abusive young man or a selfish young woman.

Not to be overlooked is that in the exhortation, “marry in the Lord,” is the admonition, “marry.” Young people ought not delay marriage unduly. Doing so exposes them to the powerful temptation of fornication. Paul authoritatively admonishes that “the younger women marry.” Failing to do this, some in Paul’s day were “already turned aside after Satan” (I Tim. 5:14-15). What this turning aside after Satan consisted of can be determined from the fact that it was the consequence of their not having married. If the command is that the young women in the church marry, in part to avoid such serious temptation as to be turned after Satan, it is implied that the young men of the church have the obligation to propose marriage to the younger women.

If one is divorced, he is called of God to abide in that unhappy state. As part of His marriage doctrine in Matthew 19, Jesus speaks of “eunuchs,” specifically of those “which have made themselves eunuchs for the kingdom of heaven’s sake” (v. 12). The reference is not to men who have physically castrated themselves, as an early church father foolishly supposed, but to those who deliberately deprive themselves sexually, as is the case with divorced Christians who, in obedience to Christ, refuse to remarry. Grace enables a man or a woman to live without a wife or without a husband. Such Christians have still the real marriage: union with Christ. They have also the hope of the fullness of marital delight everlastingly in the new world at the coming of their Husband.

If there is to be this faithful Christian practice of marriage by the members of the church, the true church of Christ must preach the truth of marriage and discipline accordingly. This is not merely a choice that the church makes but a calling. Christ gives the church her message of marriage in Matthew, Mark, Luke, Romans, I Corinthians and other passages of Scripture. This is not a popular message in the debased, adulterous culture of the twenty-first century. It was not a popular message in the first century AD either, dominated as that century was by the impure, perverse way of life of the Roman empire.

But the message of the Bible is the truth. It protects the family. It exalts Christ. It honours the God of the family. It is an inescapable, powerful witness of Christianity and its gospel to the adulterous world. It is an important aspect of the gospel’s narrow way to heaven.

House-Churchism: An Ecclesiastical Panacea or Poison? (4)

Samuel Watterson

Church Authority in the Old Testament

The pre-eminent example of church authority in the first pages of the Old Testament is Melchizedek. He is mentioned briefly, but his role as both king and priest is significant. Such was Melchizedek's position that even our father Abraham, the father of all the faithful, submitted himself to his spiritual authority. Melchizedek had the priestly authority to bless Abraham and the authority to receive tithes from Abraham. The writer to the Hebrews draws out these astounding points as an illustration of Christ's kingly and priestly offices (Heb. 7:1-10). God does not condemn Melchizedek's position of authority in the church as having pagan roots or as an obstacle to Christ's authority but He extols it as a picture of Christ (Ps. 110:4). Though the shadow must be put away now that Christ has come, the example of Melchizedek shows us that it is not at all contrary to God's will for some to have authority over others in the church. Whether this is still the case after the coming of Christ, we will later examine.

If not for Melchizedek, we would look at the patriarchs, especially Abraham, Isaac and Jacob, as the first major examples of church authority. These had authority over their families in the covenant of God, especially the authority to teach and admonish and chastise their children, including when those children were older (Gen. 18:19; 27:8; 35:1-5). They also had authority to pronounce prophetic blessings regarding their children, and to make sacrifices to God for themselves and others (Gen. 8:20; 9:25-27; 27:27-40; Ex. 18:12; Job 1:5). God gave these men authority in the church by calling them with their families into His covenant so that their families comprised the church of those days (Gen. 9:12; 17:7, 19; 26:24; 28:13). The distinct families were nevertheless autonomous. Abraham did not have authority over Rebekah's household, but sent gifts and entreaties with his servant to find a wife for Isaac (Gen. 24:5-9). Jacob did not have authority over Laban's household, but had

to labour as a hired servant and remonstrate with Laban for his daughters as wages (Gen. 29:15-30). Even Moses, at the end of the time of the patriarchs, did not have authority over Jethro's Midianite family, although the Kenite children of Hobab later joined themselves to the nation of Israel (Num. 10:29-32; Judg. 1:16; 4:11).

The prophetic office is another example of church authority during this time. This office ordinarily includes authoritative preaching of God's Word (prophetesses and a few others are exceptions). Enoch and Noah are significant examples, both prophesying and preaching of the coming judgment of God in the Flood as a picture of the end of the world (Heb. 11:7; I Pet. 3:19-20; II Pet. 2:5; Jude 14-15). The appointment of these men, as with all prophets, is a special case. The prophets were all appointed by a direct call from God. This was the case with Moses, the pre-eminent prophet of the Old Testament, as also with the subsequent prophets such as Samuel, Isaiah and Jeremiah (Ex. 3:10-14; I Sam. 3:10-20; Isa. 6:5-9; Jer. 1:4-9). By means of their prophecy itself as the authoritative Word of God and witnessed by the signs of their prophecy (such as miracles or fulfilled predictions, e.g., in typical form pointing to and confirming a later archetypal fulfilment), the church recognized that these men had been appointed as prophets by God. If any claimed the authority of the prophetic office illegitimately, they were to be stoned to death according to the Mosaic law (Deut. 13:1-5). They were to be judged as false prophets if what they claimed did not come to pass (or had not occurred) or if they promoted departure from God (e.g., teaching contrary to what He had already revealed). Only true prophets were given the authority to deliver the oracles of God. Frank Viola makes much of Moses' desire that all God's people would be prophets, but for now this suffices to demonstrate that at that time this was certainly not the case and the vast majority were not given prophetic authority. Further, although this is a special case, it is still not true that prophets took such authority upon themselves by simply deciding themselves to begin to function as prophets. They were first called to be prophets and then carried out their prophetic function as the responsibility of their prophetic office. We will return to this subject when considering New Testament prophets, whether all can, may or should prophesy and in what sense all believers are prophets.

The next historical examples of church authority in the Old Testament are the judges from Moses to Samuel (some of whom were also prophets or became

judges in connection with their prophetic office, while Moses and Samuel also performed priestly functions, both being from the tribe of Levi). The office again represented a God-given position with authority over others. The function of the office could not be carried out by those who did not have the office and being appointed to this office conferred the responsibility to carry out its authoritative function, namely to adjudicate on matters pertaining to God's law, pronounce binding judgments and even execute those judgments as an instrument in God's hand (I Sam. 15:32-33). For this latter reason, the judges were involved in warfare against Israel's enemies: sin within and the pagans without (Judg. 2:18-19; I Sam. 7:3-13). Before Moses had been officially appointed by God, his attempts to function as a judge were scoffed at as illegitimate: "Who made thee a prince and a judge over us? intendest thou to kill me, as thou killedst the Egyptian?" (Ex. 2:14). When God called him forty years later, Moses was concerned as to how the Israelites would know that he had been appointed to his office by God. The signs of the rod-serpent and the leprous hand and the plagues against Egypt were given as signs to confirm his calling and appointment as a judge and prophet whom God had sent. Later we find that Moses is the only one carrying out the function of judge in Israel when his Midianite father-in-law Jethro gives him godly advice (Ex. 18:16). Moses takes Jethro's advice to appoint other men to be judges. This was clearly a role to which one had to be authoritatively appointed. It also involved spiritual authority over others in the church, as is apparent from its function to pronounce binding judgments and also in that these men were called "rulers" or even "gods" (Ex. 18:21-26; 21:6; 22:28). Finally, we should notice in passing that the qualifications that Jethro insists upon for these judges ("able men, such as fear God, men of truth, hating covetousness") are echoed later in New Testament qualifications for elders, which we will examine later.

We also discover priestly authority in the days of Moses, in distinction from the authority of judges or of prophets. Again, this was a position to which one had to be officially appointed and which conferred the responsibility to carry out a specific function which one would not otherwise have the authority to perform (Ex. 28:1). The priestly function involved a sphere of authority over others, though not the same sphere of authority as that of prophets (speaking God's Word) or of judges (pronouncing and executing judgments). For example, only the priests had the authority to offer sacrifices to God. With regard

to priests especially, God instituted very specific ceremonies by which they had to be hallowed in order to serve in their priestly office (Ex. 29:1-35). By means of the priestly office, the entire congregation is consecrated to God in holiness, so that He is our God and we are His people, and so that God dwells among the congregation and we know that He is our God (Ex. 29:44-46). We will consider the significance of this office later in the light of the New Testament, when we turn to the unique priestly office of Christ and the office of all believers as priests. For now, notice what happened when even one with the dignity and authority of a godly king in Judah attempted to perform the function of a priest to which he had not been appointed. In the pride of his heart, Uzziah went into the temple to offer incense and was struck with leprosy with which he had to suffer for the rest of his days for his folly (II Chron. 26:16-21).

The great example in the Old Testament of God's judgment against those who reject the church authority which He has appointed and who attempt to take to themselves that authority is the rebellion of Korah, Dathan and Abiram. These men attempted to usurp the authority given to Moses and Aaron based upon essentially the same argument made by Viola: "Ye take too much upon you, seeing all the congregation are holy, every one of them, and the LORD is among them: wherefore then lift ye up yourselves above the congregation of the LORD?" (Num. 16:3). Moses' response is humbly to tell them to let the Lord show whom he has chosen (vv. 4-7). Furthermore, he rebukes them for the very thing of which they had accused him, taking too much upon himself, and points to the privileges which God had given them as Levites (vv. 7-11). None of the other tribes had the authority and privilege to serve at the tabernacle. The whole congregation would have been consumed by the wrath of God on account of this rebellion, but for the intercession of Moses and Aaron, and the congregation separating themselves from the tents of Korah, Dathan and Abiram—all in the mercy of God (vv. 19-27). What follows is one of the most remarkable and fearful demonstrations of God's approval and defence of the authority which He appointed in the church (vv. 28-35). When the people subsequently complained, the Lord sent a deadly plague among them which killed 14,700 of the congregation and would have slain more had not Aaron taken the incense and "stood between the dead and the living" (vv. 41-50). How can we understand this terrible judgment except that the gravity of rebellion against those whom Jehovah has appointed to office in the church

is rebellion against God Himself? As the Lord said to Samuel, “they have not rejected thee, but they have rejected me, that I should not reign over them” (I Sam. 8:7).

Viola imagines that Moses ascended Mount Horeb because “With the Fall came an implicit desire in people to have a physical leader to bring them to God.”¹ As the outworking of this “fallen instinct,” he claims, “The people wanted Moses to be a physical mediator between them and God because they feared a personal relationship with the Almighty.”² But Scripture paints for us a very different picture (Deut. 5:23-29). The people, including Moses, feared because God taught them to be afraid with terrifying signs so that they would know that to approach Him without a mediator is certain death (Heb. 12:20-21). It was not man’s “fallen instinct” that appointed Moses to act as a mediator but God’s perfect wisdom in presenting Moses as picture of the true Mediator, Jesus Christ (Deut. 18:15-16). This God-fearing desire for a mediator was explicitly approved by God and was the occasion for promising the true Mediator of whom Moses was a type (Deut. 18:17-19). The writer to the Hebrews leaves us with this warning: “See that ye refuse not him that speaketh. For if they escaped not who refused him that spake on earth, much more shall not we escape, if we turn away from him that speaketh from heaven” (Heb. 12:25).

These three forms of church authority (king/judge, priest/Levite and prophet/teacher) continued throughout the Old Testament with minimal variation. The king was essentially a higher judge over all the tribes, a permanent hereditary office (as opposed to an office given by God in response to prayer for deliverance), with additional rights and privileges that judges did not have. The core of their ministry was the same, to rule by pronouncing and executing judgment in Israel and upon her enemies. Godly David, when already anointed to be the next king, would not lift a finger against King Saul, the Lord’s anointed, even though Saul had shown himself to be wicked and disobedient to God. The king was anointed by the priest and later (or at the same time) installed into his office publicly. When the kingly office was dis-

¹ Frank Viola and George Barna, *Pagan Christianity? Exploring the Roots of Our Church Practices* (Wheaton, IL: Tyndale House, 2008), p. 108.

² Viola and Barna, *Pagan Christianity*, p. 109.

solved, Israel still had its elders and governors to rule and judge, with Nehemiah being the pre-eminent example after the captivity (Neh. 13:7-31). The priests and Levites were restored to their responsibilities after the captivity when the temple was rebuilt. The teaching responsibilities of the priestly and levitical offices became more prominent after the return, as exemplified by Ezra (Lev. 10:11; Neh. 8:4-8; Mal. 2:7), just as there were no more prophets until John the Baptist. To such a church, the Lord came. The Lord did not bring revolution or a rebellion (contrary to Barna and Viola's presentation of Christ as a revolutionary), but acknowledged the church authority of His day and submitted Himself personally to their authority, though exercising His own prophetic office in rebuking their hypocrisy: "The scribes and the Pharisees sit in Moses' seat: All therefore whatsoever they bid you observe, that observe and do; but do not ye after their works: for they say, and do not" (Matt. 23:2-3; cf. 26:62-64).

Of Christ's own authority and of church authority in the New Testament, we have much more to say. The strongest argument which Viola makes is based, after all, not upon a denial of church authority in the Old Testament, but upon the unique authority of Christ (i.e., as if His coming as the archetypal Mediator in His three-fold office as Prophet, Priest and King abolishes all offices entirely) and upon all New Testament believers being prophets, priests and kings (i.e., as if this precludes the possibility of special offices). Yet this survey of Old Testament church authority teaches us two important things. First, it lays the foundational basis for understanding Christ's authority and church authority in the New Testament. Second, it shows us the falsity of Viola's claims that possessing authority through a specific office in the church (positional authority) or possessing authority over others in the church (which he calls "hierarchical") are inherently pagan concepts in origin and nature. So far are these from being pagan concepts that God Himself instituted and defended precisely this form of church authority in the Old Testament, even to the extent that those who rebelled against this authority met with the severest of judgments. Using essentially the same approach, we will next expose the fatal weaknesses of Viola's main argument and see in precisely what ways the form of church authority is different in the New Testament when the church became catholic or universal. We will also review the severity of God's judgments against those who despise this church authority in the New Testament,

a reiteration which is especially important for those tempted towards the errors of Marcionism or dispensationalism in this area.

The Rule of Christ the Prophet, Priest and King

The subject of especially the Gospels but also woven throughout the entire New Testament is the one kingdom of God, of heaven and of Christ. This is the kingdom to which the Old Testament prophets bore witness. This glorious kingdom is defined in that God is the King through Jesus Christ, the promised Son of David (Luke 1:31-33). Christ's kingdom is not of this world, that is, its origin is not from this present evil age. Therefore, its principle and character are completely different from the kingdoms of this world (Heb. 1:8). Because it is a kingdom established by righteousness, it endures forever and cannot be defeated (Prov. 16:12; 25:5; 29:14; Isa. 9:7). It is the kingdom of heaven, whose character is heavenly, spiritual, righteous, holy and full of truth (John 18:36-37; Rom. 14:17).

Yet it has citizens who, because of their King, are not of this world, yet are in it (John 15:18-21; 17:14-19). The citizens of the kingdom of God are His elect people, who bear distinct characteristics and receive the blessings of this kingdom (Matt. 5:3-16; 25:34; I Pet. 2:9-10). This kingdom is composed also of elect infant citizens (Matt. 11:25; 19:14; 21:16). Those who are not His people are not citizens of His kingdom, but belong to the kingdom of darkness and Satan (Matt. 12:25-28; Eph. 2:2; Col. 1:13). Because His is a spiritual kingdom of righteousness, the citizens must also be righteous (Ps. 15:1-2; 101:6-8).

Our citizenship, therefore, is a gift of the King who Himself has given us His own perfect righteousness (II Cor. 5:19-21; Col. 1:13-14). Our entrance to this kingdom is, therefore, not something we do but a miraculous work of God's grace. There is no prerequisite for us to perform before God makes us citizens. We become citizens by a new birth according to the will of God (John 1:11-13; 3:3-8; I Pet. 1:3-4). No man can purchase or earn citizenship in this blessed kingdom (Ps. 49:7-8; cf. Acts. 22:28). Our citizenship was won and purchased by our King (Eph. 2:12-16).

As King, Christ protects and defends His citizens from all our enemies: the world, the flesh and the devil (Ps. 2; Isa. 4:2-6; 9:6-7; 11; Rom. 8:35-39). But He also rules the citizens of His kingdom. The sceptre with which He rules

us in grace is His word of truth in us, so that this is not like the ineffective, exclusively external rule of earthly kings. His rule is spiritual. He rules us with His Word in our very hearts by His Holy Spirit in us (Isa. 59:16-21; Eze. 36:26-27; Zech. 4; John 6:63; 14:15-18; Col. 3:12-17; I Pet. 1:25). Those who are not citizens, but rebels and traitors, will be smashed like a potter's vessel (Ps. 2:9; 21:8-12; 89:20-23; Isa. 60:12; Dan. 2:44-45; Rev. 2:26-27). Christ rules over them too, though not graciously but with a rod of iron (Ps. 110:5-6; Phil. 2:9-11; Rev. 12:5; 19:11-16).

He has ascended to heaven and is no longer with us bodily (John 14:28; 16:5-7; Acts 1:2-11). Having ascended, He poured out His Spirit on the church, as He had promised. It is by the Spirit of truth that Christ dwells in our hearts while He is yet in heaven (Luke 17:20-21; Rom. 8:9-11; Eph. 3:14-19; Col. 3:15-16; I John 4:13). In the Old Testament, the presence of God was hidden in the temple in thick darkness behind the veil, but now we are the temple as members of the body of Christ, and we are seated with God in heaven in Christ who dwells in us and we in Him by the union of His Spirit (I Cor. 3:16-17; 6:19; II Cor. 6:16; Eph. 2:4-7, 20-22; I Pet. 2:5). In earthly kingdoms, there is distance between the king and his subjects, and only a select few may ever come near or be heard. In the kingdom of heaven, every citizen is before the throne (Rom. 5:1-2; Eph. 2:18; 3:12; Heb. 4:14-16; 8:1-2; 10:19-22; I Pet. 3:18; Rev. 7:14-15). All believers have the status not just of citizens, but of free sons and heirs of the King (Matt. 25:34; Luke 12:32; John 8:35-36; Rom. 8:15-17; II Cor. 6:18; Gal. 4:4-7, 28-31; Heb. 3:5-6; James 2:5; I John 3:1-2).

But, since the Spirit works by means of the Word, how does Christ bring His Word to us on earth, the church militant, that we may be ruled by it?

He neither walks on earth, nor thunders from heaven, nor whispers secretly in our ears (despite the claims of certain fanatics). The gifts by which the ascended Christ communicates His authoritative Word to the church militant are listed for us in Ephesians 4:8-16. These are described as apostles, prophets, evangelists and pastors. These are the authoritative teaching offices that Christ has given to His church and by which He rules His kingdom in the New Testament age. The term "office" is used here simply to mean the authority necessary to carry out a particular role (or function) with a corresponding responsibility. House-churchism denies this authority and, therefore,

takes issue with the term “office,” and necessarily distorts the function and responsibility. To analyse this, it must first be understood more fully what these teaching offices are.

They are all temporary offices in that they will no longer be needed in heaven (to which we have not yet attained, unlike certain hyper-spirituals). They are also special offices because they are not common to every believer. Every believer has a common office along with diverse gifts but only some of these are the special offices. The key passage which instructs us on the subject of the diverse gifts of the Spirit in general is I Corinthians 12 (cf. Rom. 12:3-8). It makes clear that there are many different gifts but they are all given by the one Spirit in the one body of Christ. This body is composed of many different members with different purposes and corresponding gifts, all of which are necessary for the good of the whole body. And yet there is a proper order for all are not of equal authority, value or importance (I Cor. 12:28; 14:5). Specifically, not all are teachers (I Cor. 12:29; James 3:1). Also these offices are here listed as gifts among other lesser gifts which demonstrates that, if some fanatic makes a claim to an office, it matters not if he has many excellent gifts, if he has not received the gift of the office itself. It also shows that God does not call to office those to whom He does not also give the necessary gifts (even if such gifts must be nurtured and cultivated sufficiently through practice, training and instruction before answering a call).

By the Spirit of Christ working through these teaching offices, the Holy Scriptures have been written and given to us (Matt. 26:56; Luke 1:70; Acts 1:16; 28:25; II Tim. 3:16; Heb. 3:7; I Pet. 1:10-12; II Pet. 1:21; Rev. 19:10), and by these offices these same Scriptures are employed to teach us (Acts 17:11; II Tim. 2:2; 3:16-17; 4:2; II Pet. 1:19; 3:15-16). Therefore, some of the offices are foundational and temporary (Eph. 2:20), while others must continue until Christ returns. The miraculous offices of apostle, prophet and evangelist are no longer given because their purpose is completed, according to the principle that partial provisional measures pass away when their goal is achieved and the completed result is ready to replace them (I Cor. 13:9-10).

These offices are called miraculous because either their exercise involved miracles inherently (prophets) or their exercise was attested to by miracles (especially the apostles or evangelists). The prophets, like Ananias, Agabus

(with other prophets of both Jerusalem and Antioch), Judas Barsabas or Silas spoke by direct, that is, miraculous prophecy, rather than, for example, the ordinary prophecy of explaining and applying the Scriptures. In special cases, they were also involved in conferring offices or tasks on others by means of their prophecy (Acts 9:15-17; 13:1-3; II Tim. 1:6). Furthermore, they exercised this office by speaking their prophecies in the church assemblies, preaching and teaching with authority (Acts 15:32; I Cor. 14:29-31).

This is in distinction to Philip's daughters who "did prophesy" but were not permitted to exercise the office of prophet by teaching publicly in the church (Acts 21:9; cf. I Cor. 14:31-37; I Tim. 2:11-14). Others similarly prophesied as an attestation of the ministry of the apostles and evangelists, such as those who miraculously spoke in foreign languages at Pentecost, in Samaria, Cornelius's house or in various churches established by Paul's missionary labours (Acts 2:4-11; 8:15-18; 10:44-46; I Cor. 9:2; II Cor. 3:1-3; 12:12). Although we do not have (or need) such miraculous prophecy today, the same essential distinction still applies. Every believer has the ordinary office of prophet, to know and confess God's Word as revealed in Scripture, but not every believer has the special office (i.e., the authority) to teach and speak publicly in the church assembly.

Viola's claim that every believer has the right (i.e., authority or office) to speak or teach in the church assembly is in direct contradiction to the clear apostolic instruction which forbids women from doing so. Besides that restriction, in Corinth, which was full of miraculous gifts and prophecy, even those who held the office of prophet were not allowed to speak without restriction. In the first place, only two or at most three were permitted to speak and that strictly in turn (I Cor. 14:27-29). Others would have to wait for the next meeting. Even if some special revelation was given to another sitting by (a situation which does not arise today), the speaker had to first hold his peace before the other could begin (I Cor. 14:30-31). Paul expresses his outrage and astonishment at the disorder and chaos that had been prevailing in Corinth:

How is it then, brethren? when ye come together, every one of you hath a psalm, hath a doctrine, hath a tongue, hath a revelation, hath an interpretation. Let all things be done unto edifying (I Cor. 14:26).

His point is this: Since all things in the church must be edifying and orderly, it is absurd and manifestly unspiritual that everyone is permitted to butt into the worship service with his own thing, as if the exercise of his own gifts is more important than anything else. After laying the groundwork about the harmony of the body of Christ, the place of different gifts, the paramount importance of charity and the necessity of understanding for edification, Paul corrects the foolish practices of the Corinthians (and house-churchism) by giving a few simple instructions. No one may speak in tongues without an interpreter. For that matter, only two (or at most three) prophets may be allowed to speak and only in turn. No women may be permitted to speak at all and, in short, everything must “be done decently and in order” (I Cor. 14:40). Then it begins to become clear why churches today have an order of service in which everything is determined in advance and why only the minister of the Word (or ministers, since even today some churches have more than one) is permitted to speak.

Viola appeals to I Corinthians 14, as if it were the divine licence for house-churchism and the condemnation of an order of service, somehow not seeing that this chapter is specifically decrying and condemning such chaos. But the important point is this: Those who spoke in the church required a particular office with the authority and calling to do so, the office of prophet or teacher. House-churchism, and all advocates of lay-preaching, err when they permit anyone without such an office to speak and teach in the church. In the next article (DV), we will examine the authority of Christ exercised through the other miraculous offices of apostle and evangelist, as well as the non-miraculous special offices of teacher, overseer/elder and deacon, which authority is entirely denied by house-churchism.

Book Review: God Is Impassible and Impassioned

Dr. Julian Kennedy

*God Is Impassible and Impassioned:
Toward a Theology of Divine Emotion*

Rob Lister

Wheaton, IL: Crossway, 2012

333 pages, Paperback

Lord, thou hast been our dwelling place in all generations.
Before the mountains were brought forth, or ever thou hadst
formed the earth and the world, even from everlasting to
everlasting, thou art God (Ps. 90:1-2).

Lister's thesis is that, though God is essentially impassible, which means He is not subject to passions like we are (Acts 14:15; James 5:17), yet, because of His immutable holiness and zeal for His glory, He "responds" to the moral actions and attitudes of His creatures, and that Scripture is full of these anthropopathisms.

Q. Does God suffer or express emotion like we do? A. Only in the incarnate Christ. The eternal Trinity is forever perfectly blessed and happy.

Q. Then what about all the expressions of emotion attributed to God in Scripture? A. They are anthropopathisms: human expressions attributed to God to enable us to understand His "responses." As Bruce Ware puts it,

God is eternally passionate for his glory, and now in the context of a fallen creation, when that glory is despised, eternal passionate jealousy gives rise in God to a new and contingent expression of white-hot anger against sin (p. 226).

God is at the same time outside time and throughout time. God is transcendent (high above, separate, self-existent, self-sufficient, and outside the created order of space and time) and also immanent or omnipresent throughout

creation by His condescension. These are examples of doctrinal duality. God is also both impassable (immutable and invulnerable) and impassioned (His eternal character necessitates holy “responses” to man’s ethical behaviour).

Thomas Weinandy rightly declares,

The OT never conceives of God’s transcendence in opposition to his immanence, as if that which makes God wholly other is different from that which allows him to be a personal God who lovingly acts in time and history ... That which makes him divine, and thus wholly other, and so transcendent, is that which equally allows him to be active within the created order and so be immanent (p. 222, n. 13).

Lister states that divine impassibility is the very foundation that gives rise to God’s perfectly fitted emotional and relational “responses” to His creatures (p. 172). This duality forms the fascinating content of this book by Lister, who is an assistant professor of theology at Biola University and who has researched extensively for his thesis. His bibliography is 30 pages long!

Reading this book was important for me, because I was challenged by three different people who believe that God has passions and actually suffered in His divinity in Christ. These are: a family member, a Christian friend and the director of an important Christian charity who has just written on the subject (albeit erroneously)!

First, it is important to define terms. God being impassable means He is, in His divine being, unchanging and not subject to variable emotions like we are. In His divine tri-unity, God is forever blessed and happy. God’s being impassioned means that He expresses Himself in “response” to His creatures, albeit in scripturally anthropopathic emotions which are in line with His unchanging holiness and glory. J. I. Packer is right:

[Impassibility is] not impassivity, unconcern, and impersonal detachment in the face of creation; not insensitivity and indifference to the distresses of a fallen world; not inability or unwillingness to empathize with human pain and grief; but simply that God’s experiences do not come upon him as ours come upon us, for his are foreknown, willed and chosen for

himself, and are not involuntary surprises forced on him from outside, apart from his own decision, in the way ours regularly are (p. 238, n. 62).

Divine impassibility has been taught from the days of the church fathers and only recently has it been extensively challenged, for example, in the phrase “God suffers.” Lister quotes Irenaeus (c. 130-200):

For as he was man that he might be tempted, so also he was the Logos that he might be glorified. The Logos remained quiescent during the process of temptation, crucifixion and death, but aided the human nature when it conquered, and endured, and performed deeds of kindness, and rose again from the dead, and was received up into heaven (p. 70).

Tertullian (c. 160-225) viewed God’s responsiveness as flowing from, and being expressive of, His eternal and unchanging nature. Origen (c. 185-254), in contrast, viewed God, in His dealings with men as suffering human passions, not only in the incarnate Messiah but also in the pre-incarnate Logos and the Father as well. Athanasius (c. 296-373) instructed his readers that the incarnation was necessary to overcome the natural impassibility of the divine Being.

Augustine (354-430) further qualifies what Scripture means when attributing emotion to God:

But by the repentance of God is meant the change of things which lie within his power, unexpected by man; the anger of God is his vengeance upon sin; the pity of God is the goodness of his help; the jealousy of God is that providence whereby he does not allow those whom he has in subjection to himself to love with impunity what he forbids (p. 89).

Coming to the Reformation, Luther believed that God’s suffering is limited to the sphere of the incarnation. Regarding God’s being affected with grief, Calvin states, “God is not sorrowful or sad; but remains for ever like himself in his celestial and happy repose” (p. 116). Because it could not otherwise be known how great God’s hatred and detestation of sin is, the Spirit accommodates Himself to our capacity (using anthropathic language).

Jurgen Moltmann is typical of modern passibilist thought, repudiating any denial that the sphere of the suffering of Christ extended to His divine nature: “A God who cannot suffer is poorer than any man ... the one who cannot suffer cannot love either” (p. 128).

Another modern passibilist, H. Maldwyn Hughes, claims, “It is of the very nature of love to suffer when its object suffers loss ... If the suffering of God be denied, then Christianity ... must obliterate the statement ‘God is love’ from its Scriptures” (p. 133). But love in God existed within the Trinity from everlasting!

Taking the passibilist idea even further, Jung Young Lee states,

The Cross of Calvary *always* points to the eternal Cross ... The redemptive suffering of Christ on the Cross is a temporal manifestation of the eternal Cross ... The suffering and death of Christ on the Cross point to ... the eternal suffering and death of God on the eternal Cross (p. 138; italics Lee’s).

Lister makes “two brief observations on modern passibilist treatments of the incarnation and the cross,” namely,

First, it has been well said that the insistence of modern passibilists on ascribing suffering to the divine nature ‘renders the assumption of humanity [i.e., incarnation] superfluous’ [Paul L. Gavrilyuk]. In other words, the logic of redemptive history requires an incarnation precisely because the divine nature itself is not subject to or constituted by suffering in the sense that contemporary passibilism demands. The traditional view is that an incarnation was necessary precisely to overcome the impassibility of the divine nature. But if the divine nature is already passible, then an incarnation of a passible divine person in passible humanity would be redundant. Second, and closely related to the first observation, it is important to note that, whereas the classical view sees the cross in relation to the achievement of victory over sin, many contemporary passibilists see the cross instead merely as a sign of God’s suffering solidarity, without the accompanying assurance that this necessarily portends any final victory. In that sense, the

passibilist actually downplays the power and significance of the cross (p. 139).

Passibilist theologians fail to interpret Scripture with Scripture and are guilty of making God in our image! They emphasize the perceived human needs of contemporary culture (for empathy in suffering) alongside an immanent divine struggle against oppression and injustice. This is more in line with liberation theology and the social gospel at the expense of God's transcendence, sovereignty and immutability.

Lister rightly accuses these passibilists of abstracting the event of the cross from its context, supplying it with another meaning and thus transgressing biblical authority, because Scripture not only provides a record of the events of redemptive history but also the authorized interpretation of these events.

Richard Creel contends that God is impassible because He eternally knows all possibilities and thus His will is eternally determined regardless of which possibilities become actualities. He should be conceived as eternally willing and doing everything that He ever wills and does. God's will in time is a "pre-sponse" as opposed to a "response" (p. 151).

Lister summarizes some of Creel's false doctrines:

God's knowledge of the future is passible, because he has exhaustive knowledge only of all abstract possibilities. God's knowledge of which possibilities become actualities is dependent on their being actualized by his libertarianly free creatures ... God's primary purpose in creation was to make free creatures, who in their freedom may "choose for or against his kingdom" (p. 152).

This is free will Arminian thought!

We must *never* take Bible expressions of God's emotion literalistically. Lister summarizes God as impassioned by stating that His emotional "responses" to His fallen and repentant creatures is the in-time expression of His eternal character and passion for His glory. Furthermore, he says,

God's omniscience and sovereignty preclude the possibility of God's ever having the kind of emotional experience that

we often do, namely, the experience of an emotional reaction due to the surprisingly unexpected or unforeseen (p. 253).

At this point, it is worth mentioning Lister's errors. First, he reckons that unregenerate man is still in the image of God with the image being damaged but not destroyed, wrongly citing Genesis 5:1-3, 9:5-6 and James 3:8-9 (p. 220), for the texts in Genesis are applicable to man in his original creation and James 3 refers to man's recreation in regeneration, and ignoring Jesus's clear teaching in John 8:44 that fallen human beings, exemplified by the Pharisees, are the seed of Satan! Second, he thinks that God decrees to save all head for head (pp. 182, 233-234), contrary to Romans 9:22-23. Thus Lister holds the well-meant offer: "God's love initiates the offer of grace" (p. 179). But does not God's love irresistibly confer grace and salvation (Rom. 8:28-39)?

God rejoices (Isa. 62:5), He is grieved (Eph. 4:30), His wrath burns (Ex. 32:10), He pities (Ps. 103:13), He loves everlastingly (Isa. 54:8) and He is jealous (Ex. 20:5). But these "responses" are not like ours. Every divine display of love proceeds from the initiative of God who is eternally, perfectly and unwaveringly passionate in the union of Trinitarian love (p. 199). God's eternal passionate commitment to His own glory leads to expressions of His jealous wrath as a fitting "response" to those who betray the covenant by idolatry (Deut. 4:23-24; 6:13-15), which is tantamount to adultery, and a judgment predicted and warned about in the covenant curses (Deut. 28:15ff.). However, unlike Jehovah's love, His wrath and jealousy are not intrinsic perfections in God but His holiness flaming out against sin (p. 201). Despite our iniquities, His steadfast covenant love keeps or wins back His elect remnant (Mal. 3:6).

Regarding Isaiah 63:9, "In all their affliction he was afflicted," Lister shows that this affliction was God's intention (Ex. 4:21; p. 213). God's covenant presence was with His people in Christ, who is both God *and man*, identifying with them, upholding them and ultimately freeing them. Surely the incarnation teaches us that Jesus, the image of God, perfectly displayed for us what godly human passion should be like!

The person of the Son experienced suffering and death humanly. As Thomas Weinandy states,

If the Son of God experienced suffering in his divine nature, he would no longer be experiencing human suffering in an

authentic and genuine human manner, but instead he would be experiencing “human suffering” in a divine manner which would then be neither genuinely nor authentically human (p. 93).

One implication of all this is that by grace we will become more like Christ in His emotional perfection, “growing to love what He loves and hate what He hates.”

To sum up, Lister, I believe, thoroughly proves his thesis of an impassible yet impassioned God and, therefore, his book is a helpful preservative against modern liberal thought. This book ought to be in every theological library and is a must read for thoughtful, well-educated Christians. Highly recommended.

Plan now to attend the
**2024 British Reformed Fellowship
Family Conference**

Date: 3-10 August, 2024

Venue: Cloverley Hall,
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Topic: Eschatology

Speakers:
Rev. Ronald Hanko
Prof. Brian Huizinga

I Correspondence

The Christian Institute and the Church Calendar

From Michael Marzan-Esher:

Thank you for putting “DV” correctly in place on page 12 of the last *BRJ*. Julian Kennedy’s exposé of Common Grace (CG) and the Christian Institute (CI) will be unpopular, as indeed will be the *BRJ* itself, amongst most Christians who are not “wet blankets” as myself! In the past, I have been to CI local meetings and listened to their annual lectures, but no longer. They never responded. They reject the KJV, use a piano and CG often comes up in their meetings.

I wrote to a similar Christian organization, Christian Legal Concern, asking not to receive any e-mails and literature, but I still got their “christmas” begging material. I wrote a badly written letter, which will not be answered, just giving the following quote found in puritanboard.com by J. V. Fesko, I think.

The Church Calendar repeats the same endless cycle. Advent, Christmas, Epiphany, Lent, Ascension, Pentecost only to start over again with Advent. The biblical view, on the other hand, recognizes that the events of Christ’s ministry are in the past and that we are moving forward to a goal—the consummation of history, the return of Christ, the final judgment and eternity with our triune Lord. A cyclical view of history is at odds with the biblical view which is linear.¹

My pet hates, *inter alia*, are calling the first day of the week “Sunday” and the church calendar with which most Christians will have no problem. If it is possible, please will you be able to deal with this in the *BRJ* in a future issue?

Editor Response:

I am glad you benefit from the *BRJ*. I admit, I am not very familiar with the Christian Institute or Christian Legal Concern. Of course, if their business is

¹ While I did indeed find a link to an article by Dr. Fesko on this subject on puritanboard.com, the link was no longer working and I was unable to track down the article. If anyone knows where this can still be accessed online, let me know—Ed.

providing legal aid to Christians, I'm not so concerned about the exact theology they espouse (that is, unless they start also publishing pamphlets promoting their theology, as the Christian Institute has done). One does not always need good theology to provide effective legal aid (though good theology helps in every area to some extent), as even unbelievers can also be useful attorneys. We can appreciate, I think, much of the work these organizations do without necessarily approving all their theology.

That is an interesting quote from Fesko and I will try to find the source, but I cannot promise that we will address this in a future *BRJ* issue, as I think we have a lot more pressing topics to cover currently. I wonder how the author would address the cyclical nature of our seven-day week. It may interest you to know that, to this day, the Irish (Gaelic) names for the days of the week are Christianized to some extent. The first day of the week is “Dé Domhnach” (lit. Day of the Lord). Other days refer to various weekly fasts (a reminder of the monastic life which was once prevalent): “Dé Céadaoin” (Day of the First Fast), “Déardaoin” (Day Between Fast), “Dé hAoine” (Day of the [main] Fast). The rest, however, retain the influence of (heathen) Roman culture, referring to the false gods of Luna or the moon (“Dé Luain”), Mars (“Dé Máirt”) and Saturn (“Dé Sathairn”).

However, I do not think that anyone today or even at the time would have considered the use of these names to be affording any kind of honour or acknowledgement to these idols, as if invoking their names in a devotional sense. Few people are even really aware of their origins, much less imagine that any kind of homage is paid to these idols by using these names. We could make similar observations about the common names of various celestial objects and I would see no need to bind anyone's conscience about such matters.

Remembering Thirty Years of the *BRJ*

From Hugh L. Williams (former BRJ editor):

It is good to see you are maintaining a high standard of production of the *BRJ*. I look forward to receiving each copy. If I have one criticism it is this, it only comes twice a year.

A few matters I would appraise you of:

1) The BRJ was 30 years old in January of 2023. The first issue in 1993 carried on its cover a photograph of Prof. Hanko and Prof. Engelsma.

2) At that time in 1993 three other new journals were competing for readers, as follows:

(i) *Calvinism Today* (which later changed its name to *Christianity and Culture*): This was a hefty intellectual production of the Kuyper Foundation, initially quarterly in A4 size. The Kuyper Foundation was set up by one Stephen Perks as a British organization with roughly the same aims as the Rushdoony-orientated preterist postmillennial organization in the USA, and it had some peculiar emphases regarding the nature of the church and the necessity of Christians being active politically to change human society legislatively. Much of its emphasis was commendable but it had some distinct, and in my opinion, peculiar views embodied in the whole package. This all got a grip in the BRF in the years 1998 to 2002, and caused a serious upset and rift in the whole BRF, which involved my resignation as editor and the appointment of Allen Baird, who was sympathetic, at least, to the Kuyper Foundation emphasis.

Today, the people enamoured by the Kuyper Foundation are no longer with the BRF. In 2002, they were active in the dismantling of the Ballymena Covenant Reformed Church, from which Rev. Angus Stewart has, by God's grace, been enabled, with a few of the old stalwarts, effectively to rebuild the congregation again. The upheaval in the BRF brought about a radical change in the orientation and standard of the BRJ, and a serious 60 percent cut in its subscription base, which latter, I believe, has not been regained. As to the Kuyper Foundation and its journal, you can see it still exists via its website but it seems to me that it has lapsed into something of a low profile. I believe for the moment it is "asleep" and its journal is no longer published, nor do they organize any conferences.

(ii) James Begg Society and its journal: Set up by Scottish Calvinists in about 1994, they worked among the faithful of the Free Kirk of Scotland, and were active propagating and advocating a radical overhaul of the goings-on in the Free Kirk. This resulted in the schism of about 1999, when the Free Church (Continuing) denomination was set up. Having run a well-produced magazine for some years and republished some worthy old Scots theological tomes, the

organization and its magazine now seems to have disappeared all together. I suppose its *raison d'être* was rendered somewhat unnecessary due to the new denomination and its monthly denominational magazine.

(iii) Christian Research Society and its journal: Set up at about the same time as the BRF, it operated out of somewhere in eastern England. The journal carried critical analyses of the multi-variant trends in modern evangelicalism in Britain but after about 5 years or so it all disappeared, after publishing some useful material.

3) You will see that by God's grace the *BRJ* has still survived despite wholesale criticism from mainstream evangelicalism in the British Isles. It seems to me that it has the potential for regaining the ground it lost in the crisis period of 1998-2002. If I may make the following suggestions:

First, the marketing and subscription side of the *BRJ* needs a special boost, perhaps by organizing it under its own marketing committee which would also shoulder the burden of advertising and mailing. Overseas and the mission fields of Asia were opening up to it back in 1998, much of which was lost during the disruption of 1998-2002. I remember posting a parcel of about a dozen to twenty to just one of our subscribers in Singapore. Another lot went out to Australia and more to India.

Second, a return to "quarterly" status. This would obviously double your work as editor, which is another reason why I suggest that all other concerns (of the marketing, etc.) be shouldered by a team set up to serve this need.

4) Finally, I presume that you have been apprised of the fact that all my copies of the *BRJ* from No. 1 to No. 8 (when the late Tony Horne was editor) and thereon from No. 9 to the last one I produced in 2001 are now in the hands of David Hutchings, who I understand is digitizing all of them plus some further issues. My copies in David's hands are all in practically mint condition, and ought eventually to be bound and deposited with you as editor. Together with them is an index to Subjects and an index to Contributors, researched and printed by Tony Horne just a few years before he passed on.

My thanks to you for your faithful and laborious work as Editor.

Editor Response:

Thank you for sharing this piece of BRJ history and for an overview of contemporary Christian journals in the British Isles for our current readership. Knowing this history is helpful: “I remember the days of old; I meditate on all thy works; I muse on the work of thy hands” (Ps. 143:5). The simple purpose of the *BRJ* to promote the knowledge of the Reformed faith is still as relevant and worthwhile as when it began, and we may be thankful it continues to serve this purpose.

As for improvements in marketing or subscriptions, I am very happy to continue to leave that to the genius and labour of others. My small contribution in this area has been to start an editor’s blog and share content on social media (britishreformed.org/blog). Any willing volunteers and people with concrete ideas are welcome to contact the BRF Council. My thanks to you and David Hutchings (along with our webmaster and other helpers) for your contributions in ensuring past issues of the *BRJ* are available in good quality on-line (britishreformed.org/journal/issues).

Whether we can achieve a return to “quarterly” status depends on various factors. First, there are various competing demands on my time and energy. Sitting in front of a computer solving complicated software problems all day is not very conducive to having the mental energy for sitting in front of a computer in the evening reading, writing, editing and proof-reading complicated theological articles, assuming my wife and children do not also need my time in the evenings. If I were just writing the editorials, maybe we could manage “quarterly” publications but, as previously mentioned, we need more writers (ideally from the British Isles) who will produce articles of suitable quality on appropriate topics for our readers. I have a long list of articles that I would like to write myself (if I find the time and energy) but I would be even happier to see someone else write competently on these subjects. I would appreciate your prayers for me (that I would have more time, energy, faithfulness, discipline and zeal) and for this work generally.

Therefore said he unto them, The harvest truly is great,
but the labourers are few: pray ye therefore the Lord of the
harvest, that he would send forth labourers into his harvest
(Luke 10:2).

